BACKGROUND MUSIC

The ways in which we were parented, plus our life experiences, shape who we are as parents





Positive patterns (e.g., ways of expressing love, tradition)

Challenging patterns (e.g., which emotions are "allowed" and how they are expressed)

Subconsciously learned and passed on

OUR EXPERIENCES ARE THE 'BACKGROUND MUSIC' OF OUR LIVES

Calm music = positive experiences

- Lead us to be open to new experiences
- Assume more good things will happen to us

Scary music = negative experiences

- Cause us to respond defensively and cautiously
- Assume more bad things will happen to us



"BACKGROUND MUSIC" AFFECTS HOW WE THINK AND FEEL

- A walk in the woods would feel scary if the Jurassic Park music is playing!
- Similarly, our own 'background music' can affect how we parent



(Universal Pictures, 1990)

CHANGING THE VOLUME ON OUR BACKGROUND MUSIC

We can't completely "turn off" our scary background music, or undo what has happened

Goal: "Turn down the volume" enough that we can focus less on our scary music and more on our kids and their needs

WE ARE NOT HELPLESS. WE CAN RECOGNIZE THE MUSIC AND MAKE CHOICES ON HOW TO RESPOND.

- We are more likely to do this if we practice recognizing the music that is playing in the background.
- In this way, our kids don't have to share our scary music.

Using calm down strategies when our scary music comes up **helps us make different choices and change patterns for our kids**

MANY PARENTS WHO EXPERIENCED **CHALLENGING OR TRAUMATIC CHILDHOODS** CAN FIND IT **PARTICULARLY HARD** TO TURN DOWN THE VOLUME ON THEIR SCARY MUSIC

- This is a common and natural reaction to challenging childhood experiences
- Seeking support from a therapist can help you process these experiences and change parenting patterns
- Look for a therapist with expertise in both trauma and parenting

ADAPTED FROM THE MOM POWER VIRTUAL GROUP CURRICULUM (MUZIK & ROSENBLUM ET AL., UNPUBLISHED MANUAL, 2021)